

EDGE RANK

Ever wondered what ticks the news feed feature on your Facebook page? The Edge Rank algorithm is the secret recipe behind it!

Read here at <http://tcrn.ch/9eSao8> to find more on how Edge Rank works.

FUTURE OF TECHNOLOGY

An interesting infographic on technologies of the future.

These are mere predictions and could be slightly incorrect, still interesting though. Find it here <http://bit.ly/eKisgs>

THE AGE OF RELEVANCE

Tech enthusiasts might often debate about the next big thing after social networking. A shift in paradigm is already taking place where people are moving from social sharing to more personalised, but relevant content seeking. Read more on <http://tcrn.ch/gWrTJL>

RUSTOCK TAKEDOWN

Rustock, one of the world's most infamous botnet was taken down recently. Apparently the cyber crooks behind it were paying \$10,000 per month to the command and control servers in the US before it was knocked out. Read more on. <http://bit.ly/eK6lk4>

Is There a Cure for Bad Apps?

- By Lance Ulanoff

Apple has pulled the “Gay Cure” app and may target others, but is that really the responsibility of companies running app store?



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Apple, Google, Microsoft, RIM - and even Amazon - are all in the app business. Some much, much more than others. These virtual software stores are considered something of a retail revolution. You can find virtually any kind of software in each of these application repositories: They're like department stores full of products right on your smartphone. They don't sell towels, Tupperware, or toys, but applications are, as we know, incredibly versatile. They can do almost anything, and that's where the trouble begins.

Considering that this is all just software—how much trouble can you really get into with an app? I've heard of disgusting ones, like the Fart App, and products that feature truly objectionable or horrid ideas (one had something to do with shaking a baby). In that way, these app stores are like your local library, which features as many books as possible without much censorship, if any at all. There's great literature and high art and, one shelf over, graphic novels depicting—if you've ever read *Watchmen* - a stranded pirate using dead shipmates as bloated flotation devices. If you don't want to read this kind of story, then you can walk right by that shelf.

In an app store as large as Apple's (300,000 apps and counting), it's easy to miss most apps—people tend to see the Featured

and Popular ones. A search, though, can help you discover apps for all sorts of topics. We learned this week, for example, that all the major app stores, Apple's, RIM's and Google's, feature apps that can help drunk drivers elude DUI checkpoints. U.S. Senators took exception to this and have now called for their removal from all the app stores. It's a noble cause. Drunk driving is a scourge on society. Over a quarter of a million people are injured in drunk-driving accidents each year and some 13,000 die. No one should be evading DUI checkpoints—they might want to avoid the liquor store, though—is there an app for that?

This isn't the first, nor will it be the last, questionable app category. Apple, which has both the largest and most popular app store, has been dealing with questionable apps for years. A booty shaking app was another notable winner of the headline “Most Offensive App Ever.” There was the aforementioned Baby Shaker (since pulled) and just this week a Gay Cure App (also pulled). Not every app is so obviously outside the lines of good sense or taste. Earlier this year at CES, I saw a number of apps that turned your phones into speed trap detectors. Run any one of them and you could avoid ticket hot zones while going as fast as you want when the cops aren't looking. This would seem to encourage reckless behavior, yet I don't remember anyone getting particularly upset about their existence.

Sometimes it's not the content of the apps that's the problem, but what's lurking underneath the surface. Last month Google reached

out and pulled Android apps not only from the store, but directly off Android users' phones to protect them from malware-carrying apps. Apparently these products would do one thing on the surface while trying to secretly steal your personal info, but only got fairly useless device identifying codes.

Consumers were not only shocked at what Google found, but the way in which it took action. As most people know, Apple's App Store is one of the most tightly controlled product markets around. Apple vets each and every one of the apps and the approval process can be arduous. Most assumed that the Android Market was a bit more like the wild west. There isn't really a vetting process. Google's Android Developers guide counsel much testing, but if you follow the guidelines, including obtaining a “suitable cryptographic key”, you can publish the app and then offer it in the Android Market or even from your own Web servers. So it came as quite a surprise that Google could somehow identify and nuke specific apps right off anyone's phone. On the other hand, they were acting in consumers' best interests.

I am glad Google saved consumers from themselves by removing malware-infested apps, and I applaud Apple's decision to stop offering Shaken Baby and, more recently, Gay Cure. On the other hand, this is a very slippery slope. Many people already complain about Apple's often confusing, inconsistent, and seemingly cavalier attitude toward app approval, denial, and removal. Are we saying that this attitude is okay when we agree with the actions? Similarly, doesn't it concern people that Google can reach out and touch any phone running Android?

Microsoft regularly sends system updates